



Basic facts about North Korea

Democratic People's Republic of Korea (DPRK or DPR Korea)

Capital: Pyongyang

Government: Unitary one-party Republic

Party Chairman: Kim Jong-un

Foundation: 9 September 1948

Current Constitution: 27 December 1972

Admitted to the UN: 17 September 1991

Population: • 2016 estimate - 25,368,620

• 2008 census - 24,052,231

GDP (PPP): • Total - \$40 billion

• Per capita - \$1,800

GDP (nominal): • Total - \$25 billion

• Per capita - \$1,000

Gini coefficient: very few estimates available - 0.66 to 0.85 during the period 2002-04

Infant mortality rate (per 1,000 live births): 48% (3,2 in France)

Energy consumption per capita (kilograms oil equivalent): 799 – 2007 / 475 - 2014 (Fr: 3,690; US: 6,804; SK: 5,413; Zambia: 645; Yemen: 329)



Flag of People's Democratic Republic of Korea, adopted in 1948, following its release from Soviet occupation after WWII. The flag was designed by the Soviet Union.



White is a traditional colour of Korea. On the flag it represents the purity of the ideas of North Korea. It also shows strength and dignity.



The Red Star is a symbol of Communism. It also represents the people's happy prospects of the Korean Worker's Party leadership.

The white disc is suggested to be a reminiscent of the traditional Korean Taeguk, the symbol of the universe.



The red colour symbolizes North Korea's revolutionary spirit and its path towards Socialism.



The blue colour stands for North Korea's commitment to peace and friendship.

How to discuss human rights listening to refugees' stories?

How is life in North Korea?

The Hermit Kingdom, one of the most closed-off places in the world, has experienced increasingly severe food shortages in recent years.



Childhood in North Korea can be difficult. Many children in rural areas must work on farms and forced labor drives much of the country's economic output.



Malnutrition affects a shocking number of North Korean children — roughly 28% of kids under 5 have stunted growth.



Poverty and hunger are most acute in North Korea's countryside. An estimated 41% of the population, or 10.5 million people, are believed to be undernourished.



Is the economy stabilizing?

A number of North Korean defectors and recent visitors told The Wall Street Journal that factories in the country are expanding their output and living conditions in certain areas are better than they were.



The regime keeps a tight control over what information the public can consume.



Is the army a regime supporter?

One of the most telling aspects of North Korean life is its military. The country's leader, Kim Jong Un, loves to show off its military might, holding flashy parades and distributing propaganda photos of vast armies of marching soldiers.



But it's rarer to capture photos that show the flipside of military life. North Korean soldiers are often malnourished or ill because of rigorous training and a lack of food.



As one soldier defected in 2017, others shot him five times. Defections aren't uncommon, though the number of people who did has significantly dropped over the last few years (~2500 in 2010/~1000 in 2020/~150 in 2022). South Korea attributes the falling number in part to tighter border security.



Surgeons in South Korea made a shocking discovery as they rushed to treat his wounds: the man was riddled with parasites. The parasitic worms, some of which were 11 inches long, illustrate the poor conditions in North Korea. The country still uses human excrement to fertilize its crops, a practice that can spread parasites.



Do people have rights?

Another disturbing aspect of life in North Korea is the country's notorious prison camps, where citizens — some of whom were found to have committed minor infractions that wouldn't be considered crimes in other countries — can face appalling conditions.

- Jongori prison camp



Prisoners in these so-called re-education camps are often starved and forced to do hard labor. Some survivors have reported harsh interrogations and even torture. Though there aren't photos of the camps, they're visible on Google Earth.

- The Kaechon "re-education" camp



Shin Dong-hyuk life in Camp 14

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8SAWKDRHZuw>

UN 2014 Report: <https://www.channel4.com/news/north-korea-united-nations-report-crimes-against-humanity>

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Q42kRVCCkcQ>



Prisoners' views:

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=HhS0aK8WuYE&t=49s>

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=cZby_vxrJ0Q

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=1mTZjWePlxl>

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=oWyLyj7gSio>

The border - DMZ

